SYNTHETIC DEMO POLICY — NOT A REAL HEALTH PLAN POLICY

Medical Policy: MRI knee — Coverage criteria

Policy number: RHP-IMG-022 Version: 2.1
Effective date: 2026-04-01 Applies to: Regional Health Plan (all lines)
CPT codes: 73721 (lower extremity joint, without contrast)

1. Purpose

Defines when outpatient MRI of the knee is medically necessary for members.

2. Covered when ONE of the following is documented

A. Suspected meniscus or ligament tear with mechanical symptoms (locking, catching, giving way) or a positive exam test (McMurray, Lachman, drawer), AND a knee X-ray, AND failure of at least 4–6 weeks of conservative care (PT, activity change, NSAIDs).

B. Acute injury with inability to bear weight or a locked knee (conservative care not required); X-ray first to rule out fracture.

C. Suspected infection, tumor or osteonecrosis.

D. Planning for knee surgery.

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Medical Policy: MRI knee — Documentation and exclusions

3. Required documentation

- Clinical note with mechanism of injury, symptoms and exam findings
- Knee X-ray report
- Records of conservative care (PT notes with dates and response)

4. Not medically necessary

- Knee pain without mechanical symptoms or exam findings, before conservative care
- Osteoarthritis already shown on X-ray, unless surgery is being planned

5. Review

A nurse reviewer applies these criteria. Requests that do not meet them are referred to a medical director. Only a medical director may issue an adverse determination.

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